conversation on neutral ground.

Online, Lindsay and I had become total confidants, and I was afraid of losing our connection in person. In other words, I was afraid of being rejected.

I shouldn't have been.

Lindsay—who'd insisted on driving—told me that she'd pick me up at my mother's condo. The appointed hour found me standing outside in the twilight cold, guiding her by phone through the similarly named, identical-looking streets of my mother's development. I was keeping an eye out for a gold '98 Chevy Cavalier, when suddenly I was blinded, struck in the face by a beam of light from the curb. Lindsay was flashing her brights at me across the snow.

"Buckle up." Those were the first words that Lindsay said to me in person, as I got into her car. Then she said, "What's the plan?"

It's then that I realized that despite all the thinking I had been doing about her, I'd done no thinking whatsoever about our destination.

If I'd been in this situation with any other woman, I'd have improvised, covering for myself. But with Lindsay it was different. With Lindsay, it didn't matter. She drove us down her favorite road—she had a favorite road—and we talked until we ran out of miles on Guilford and ended up in the parking lot of the Laurel Mall. We just sat in her car and talked.

It was perfection. Talking face-to-face turned out to be just an extension of all our phone calls, emails, and chats. Our first date was a continuation of our first contact online and the start of a conversation that will last as long as we will. We talked about our families, or what was left of them. Lindsay's parents were also divorced: her mother and father lived twenty minutes apart, and as a kid Lindsay had been shuttled back and forth between them. She'd lived out of a bag. Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays she slept in her room at her mother's house. Tuesdays, Thursdays, and Saturdays she slept in her room at her father's house. Sundays were the dramatic day, because she had to choose.

She told me how bad my taste was, and criticized my date apparel: a button-down shirt decorated with metallic flames over a wifebeater and jeans (I'm sorry). She told me about the two other guys she was dating, whom she'd already mentioned online, and Machiavelli would've blushed at the ways in which I set about undermining them (I'm not sorry). I told her everything, too, including the fact that I wouldn't be able to talk to her about my work—the work I hadn't even started. This was ludicrously pretentious, which she made obvious to me by nodding gravely.

I told her I was worried about the upcoming polygraph required for my